

The Plot Thickens

Who Owns Canada — And Who Decides Which Canadians Are Worth Protecting?

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The money exists. The Heritage Fund stands at \$31.9 billion. The federal benefit exists. The only thing missing is the political will to let it reach the people it was meant to serve.

CANADA'S OWNERSHIP CLASS

Canada's wealth is not distributed across its population. It is concentrated — tightly, deliberately, and generationally — in the hands of a small number of billionaire families whose ownership networks span nearly every industry in the country.

The McCain Family. The Katz Family. The Fidani Family. The Richardson Family. The Saputo Family. The Rogers Family. The Pattison Family. The Irving Family. The Weston Family. The Thomson Family.

None of them have ever had to prove their worth to a caseworker. None of them have ever been told that their needs are “unsustainable.” None of them have ever had to choose between medication and groceries, or between keeping the lights on and paying rent.

In 2025, Canada's 40 wealthiest individuals saw their combined wealth grow by more than 20 percent — adding \$95 billion in a single year. The Thomson family alone holds a net worth of \$90.2 billion. The Westons: \$20.6 billion. The Rogers family: \$11.9 billion. The top 1 percent of Canadians hold nearly \$1.25 trillion in wealth — almost as much as the bottom 80 percent combined. [1, 2, 3]

THE HERITAGE FUND: \$31.9 BILLION IN RESERVE

Alberta sits on a Heritage Fund worth \$31.9 billion as of December 31, 2025 — a savings account built on the resource wealth extracted from this province's land. That land belongs to Albertans. That wealth belongs to Albertans. [4]

The fund has nearly doubled in six years, from \$16.3 billion in 2019–20. The government's stated goal is to grow it to \$250 billion by 2050.

“The most solemn duty of any government — to ensure that future generations are able to enjoy the same benefits and quality of life that we do today.” — Premier Danielle Smith, on the Heritage Fund’s growth target [5]

And yet, when it came time to decide whether disabled Albertans deserve stable, predictable income support — the government chose to dismantle AISH and replace it with ADAP. A program delivering \$200 less per month. A program with no guaranteed cost-of-living increases written into legislation. A program going live July 1, 2026, with key regulations still being finalized as of this writing. [6]

WHAT ADAP ACTUALLY IS — AND WHAT IT ISN’T

ADAP — the Alberta Disability Assistance Program — goes live July 1, 2026. All 79,300 current AISH recipients will be automatically transitioned to it. [7]

The financial picture is stark: ADAP pays \$1,740 per month versus AISH’s \$1,940 — a \$200 monthly reduction. The earned income exemption drops from \$1,072 per month to \$350. Bill 12, passed December 9, 2025, removed from legislation the requirement for annual cost-of-living increases. A government medical panel will determine who qualifies to return to AISH — and its decisions are “final and not subject to appeal.” [8, 9]

Recipients have been told, in effect: trust us.

University of Calgary economist Gillian Petit has analyzed the data: in 2023–24, only 16.4 percent of AISH clients had any employment income. That means 83.6 percent had zero — and will be financially worse off under ADAP. The Alberta Medical Association has called the transition “punitive and excessive.” The Alberta Doctors’ Digest has documented physician alarm at the administrative burden being placed on an already-strained primary care system. [10, 11]

For people living with permanent, complex, and well-documented disabilities — many of whom have been continuously eligible for AISH for a decade or more — “trust us” is not a transition plan. It is an abandonment of responsibility.

THE CANADA DISABILITY BENEFIT CLAWBACK

The federal government created the Canada Disability Benefit (CDB) specifically to provide additional financial support to disabled Canadians living in poverty. Budget 2024 committed \$6.1 billion over six years. Payments began in July 2025 — up to \$200 per month for eligible recipients aged 18 to 64. [12]

ALBERTA IS THE ONLY PROVINCE IN CANADA THAT CLAWS IT BACK. *Every other province allows disabled residents to keep this federal benefit. Alberta deducts it dollar-for-dollar from AISH. The federal government sends the money. Alberta takes it back. The recipient sees nothing. [13, 14]*

The federal government publicly expressed disappointment, urging Alberta to reconsider “or to reinvest the funds into programs that will directly benefit persons with disabilities.” Alberta has not reversed course. [15]

“At a time when the province is cutting income tax because it made an election promise to do so, they’re basically imposing a 10-per-cent tax on disability.” — Trish Bowman, CEO, Inclusion Alberta [16]

Even before the CDB clawback, AISH left recipients \$6,004 below Canada’s official poverty line annually. The move to ADAP will push Albertans below the deep-poverty threshold entirely. [17]

THIS IS NOT AN OVERSIGHT. *This is a policy choice.*

RIGHTS HOLDERS ARE NOT JUST STAKEHOLDERS

A stakeholder is defined as an individual or group that derives benefits from the use of resources, holds legal or de facto rights to manage or make decisions, or is concerned about a particular issue. Disabled Albertans are not stakeholders in their own survival. They are rights holders.

Their rights are protected under the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms, the Alberta Human Rights Act, and the United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UN CRPD) — a treaty Canada has ratified. Article 28 of the CRPD explicitly recognizes “the right of persons with disabilities to an adequate standard of living for themselves and their families.” [18]

A government that dismantles income support without a defined replacement, without adequate consultation, and without a formal appeal process is not engaging stakeholders. **It is violating rights.**

Inclusion Alberta noted that the January 2025 consultation meetings — held two weeks before ADAP was announced — “came too late to be genuine consultations.” The engagement guide was released in August 2025, with a September 12 response deadline. Legislation was passed in December. [19]

ASK THE RIGHT QUESTIONS

Who owns Canada? The billionaire families whose names appear in ownership networks stretching across every sector of the economy — media, telecoms, food, oil, forestry, finance.

Who decides which Canadians are worth protecting? Right now, in Alberta, that answer is being written in real time — by a government that has the resources to act differently, and is choosing not to.

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown is a public group documenting these decisions in real time. Every cut. Every clawback. Every door slammed. Find us on Facebook: facebook.com/share/g/1CrU5PfHha/

SOURCE INDEX

All sources are publicly available and independently verifiable. Where government sources and advocacy sources conflict, both are cited so readers may assess the record directly.

Section 1 — Canada's Ownership Class & Wealth Inequality

[1] *The Rise of the Super-Rich: The State of Inequality in Canada*. Oxfam Canada (January 2026). oxfam.ca Key finding: Canada's 40 wealthiest individuals saw wealth grow over 20% in 2025, adding \$95 billion. The Thomson family holds \$90.2B; Weston \$20.6B; Rogers \$11.9B. The top 1% holds nearly \$1.25 trillion — nearly as much as the bottom 80% combined.

[2] *Canada's Richest 86 Families As Wealthy As Poorest 6.2 Million*. The Maple / Canadians for Tax Fairness & BC Policy Solutions (March 2026). readthemaple.com Key finding: 86 billionaire families held as much wealth as Canada's 6.2 million least wealthy families in 2023. The Thomsons were the richest family in Canada in both 1999 and 2025.

[3] *Mapping the Ownership Network of Canada's Billionaire Families*. Economics from the Top Down (Blair Fix & DT Cochrane) (2023). economicsfromthetopdown.com Key finding: Detailed ownership mapping of the McCain, Katz, Fidani, Richardson, Saputo, Rogers, Pattison, Irving, Weston, and Thomson families across Canadian industries.

Section 2 — Alberta Heritage Fund

[4] *Heritage Savings Trust Fund — Official Government Data*. Alberta Treasury Board and Finance (December 31, 2025). alberta.ca Key finding: As of December 31, 2025, Heritage Fund net financial assets were \$31.9 billion. Government target is \$250 billion by 2050.

[5] *Alberta's Heritage Fund Hits \$30B After \$2.8B Injection from Surplus*. CBC News (July 19, 2025). cbc.ca Key finding: Fund nearly doubled in six years. Premier Smith quoted: "The most solemn duty of any government is to ensure that future generations are able to enjoy the same benefits and quality of life that we do today."

[6] *Alberta Government's New Budget Officially Puts a Halt to Heritage Fund Deposits*. Fraser Institute (February 26, 2026). fraserinstitute.org Key finding: Government projects \$4.1B deficit in 2025–26 and \$9.4B in 2026–27. No Heritage Fund deposits planned for 2026. Heritage Fund has received less than 4% of total resource revenue since 1976.

Section 3 — AISH to ADAP Transition

[7] *Alberta Disability Assistance Program — Official Program Page*. Government of Alberta (2026). alberta.ca
Key finding: All current AISH clients transition to ADAP July 1, 2026. Medical review panel decisions are final and not subject to appeal.

[8] *ADAP Would Cut AISH by \$200/Month: The Facts and How to Take Action*. Inclusion Alberta (December 2025). inclusionalberta.org Key finding: ADAP pays \$1,740/month vs. AISH \$1,940. Earned income exemption drops from \$1,072 to \$350/month. Bill 12 removed mandatory cost-of-living increase provisions from legislation. Calgarians on ADAP will fall below the deep-poverty threshold.

[9] *AISH Recipient, Advocates Worry About Alberta's New Disability Benefit Program*. CBC News (August 2025). cbc.ca Key finding: Medical review panel decisions are “final and not subject to appeal.” University of Calgary economist Gillian Petit: “All I see is the government saving money and people with disabilities falling further into poverty.”

[10] *Blog: More Cuts for People on AISH*. Friends of Medicare (September 2025). friendsofmedicare.org Key finding: 83.6% of AISH clients had zero employment income in 2023–24 and will be worse off under ADAP. Alberta employment exemptions dropping from \$1,000 to \$350/month. Alberta is the only province clawing back the CDB.

[11] *Pushing Back Against Changes That Make Life Harder for Disabled Albertans*. Alberta Doctors' Digest / Alberta Medical Association (November–December 2025). albertadoctors.org Key finding: AMA President called transition “punitive and excessive.” Physicians documented administrative burden on primary care. Former AMA President Dr. Shelley Duggan warned of “decisions made without sufficient consultation with patients, physicians or subject-matter experts.”

Section 4 — Canada Disability Benefit Clawback

[12] *Question Period Note: Canada Disability Benefit*. Government of Canada / Employment and Social Development Canada (June 2025). search.open.canada.ca Key finding: Federal government committed \$6.1B over six years. Regulations in force May 15, 2025. Government “disappointed” by Alberta clawback and urged reconsideration.

[13] *Will the CDB Affect Other Benefits?* Plan Institute / CanadaDisabilityBenefit.ca (2025). canadadisabilitybenefit.ca Key finding: Alberta is the only province/territory that announced a CDB clawback. Clawbacks applied to AISH dollar-for-dollar.

[14] *CDB Clawback Map of Canada*. Disability Without Poverty (2025). disabilitywithoutpoverty.ca Key finding: All other provinces publicly declared no CDB clawbacks. Alberta officially declared it will claw back.

[15] *Alberta to Claw Back Federal Disability Benefit from AISH Recipients*. CBC News (March 27, 2025). cbc.ca Key finding: Minister Jason Nixon defended the clawback. MLA Marie Renaud: “I don’t think it’s something they’re particularly proud of.” Federal government publicly expressed disappointment.

[16] *Canada Disability Benefit in Alberta: The Facts and How to Take Action*. Inclusion Alberta (2025). inclusionalberta.org Key finding: Inclusion Alberta CEO Trish Bowman: “At a time when the province is cutting

income tax because it made an election promise to do so, they're basically imposing a 10-per-cent tax on disability."

[17] *Alberta — Welfare Incomes Across Canada*. Maytree (2024). maytree.com Key finding: AISH recipients remain \$6,004 below Canada's official poverty line annually even at maximum benefit. Households on AISH have lived in poverty in all but one of the last 19 years.

Section 5 — Rights Framework & Consultation Failures

[18] *UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (CRPD) — Article 28*. United Nations (Ratified by Canada 2010). un.org Key finding: Article 28 recognizes the right of persons with disabilities to an adequate standard of living. Canada has ratified the CRPD and is bound by its obligations.

[19] *Understanding the Proposed Changes to AISH and ADAP — Responding to the ADAP Survey*. Inclusion Alberta (September 2025). inclusion.alberta.org Key finding: January 2025 ministry meetings came "too late to be genuine consultations." Discussion guide released August 2025 with September 12 deadline. Bill 12 passed December 9, 2025.

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